

GARDENS



LIKE LANDSCAPES in miniature, gardens are set-aside areas of land where plants are grown to provide beauty and relaxation. Gardens have a practical purpose too. From ancient times, they have helped people nurture plants for food and medicine. They reduce noise and air pollution in cities, and create a refreshing environment in a hot climate. Glorious landscaped gardens can enhance the finest modern buildings, and botanic gardens are places of scientific study.

Development of gardens

Gardens have an ancient history. They were planted in Mesopotamia, China, Egypt, Persia, and Greece. The Romans spread knowledge of gardening to northern Europe during their rule of the Mediterranean lands. From the 4th century AD, when Roman power declined, monks continued the tradition of cultivating plants in monastery gardens. European gardens were enclosed by abbey or castle walls until the Renaissance.



China and Japan

Gardens in China and Japan often have a religious significance, where nature itself is honoured. This tradition is centuries old. For Zen Buddhists, landscaped gardens of raked gravel, where a rock may represent a mountain, are places of silent meditation.

Temple garden, Kyoto, Japan



Clipped shrubs

Islamic gardens

North African Moors created shady courtyard gardens, with pools and fountains to reflect the sky and cool the air. When they conquered Spain in the 8th century, the Moors took the style to Europe, as seen in the Court of the Myrtles, the Alhambra, Spain.

Renaissance formality

During the Renaissance in the 14th century, architects planned gardens as settings for the grand houses they designed. Fashionable gardens were formal, open, and regular, reviving a style established by the Romans.



Villa Lante, Bagnaia, Lazio, Italy

Botanic gardens

In botanic gardens, specimen plants are collected and cultivated for scientific study. They developed from the herb or physic gardens tended by medieval monks, where plants were grown for medicinal purposes.



Plant collectors

From the late 1600s, European explorers returned from their world expeditions with many new and exotic varieties of plant. Serious plant-collecting expeditions began in the 18th century, bringing back specimens for scientific study and to decorate gardens.

The peony, a native of China, was taken to Europe by plant collectors.

18th-century naturalism

The Jardin Anglais (English garden) style spread through Europe during the 18th century. The trend was first set by the English architect William Kent (c.1685–1748), who planned less formal gardens than had been common previously. He used an open style, which he believed to look more natural, to set off the formality of his buildings.



Chiswick House, London, England

This small classical temple, in a wooded glade, is typical of the Jardin Anglais style.

Roberto Burle Marx

Brazilian garden designer Roberto Burle Marx (1909–1994) created stunning gardens for modern buildings in Brazil, using only plants native to his country. He made Brazilians more aware of the amazing plants found in their countryside.



Wildlife gardens

In the 20th century, gardeners became more interested in the wild creatures that inhabited their plants, trees, and ponds. Instead of treating them as pests, they welcomed wildlife. Careful planting of a wildlife garden creates many different habitats, encouraging the widest possible range of animal visitors.



Gardeners plant flowers that attract insects.



Tools

Gardeners use a variety of tools. Some have hardly changed in hundreds of years, such as forks. Mechanical aids such as the lawnmower, invented in 1832, are relatively new developments.

Spade and fork

Watering can

Trowel

Hand fork